deux pas vers la chambre

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deux pas vers la chambre

by argentskyflower

Summary

The presence of Audrey's new model at a party sparks something between Nathalie and Gabriel.

Notes

have some smut to quench your thirsty souls after that finale

See the end of the work for more notes

“Nathalie, hide me—” is all the warning she gets as Gabriel Agreste inserts himself behind her, in the narrow space between her and the wall at the back of the party. His breath is hot against her neck, his suit is brushing against the bare skin of her back, and his hand settles on the curve of her waist.

She stiffens. “What are you doing?”

“Hiding.” Gabriel huffs. From this close, he smells of lavender and sandalwood with a hint of the wine he’d been nursing the last time she saw him.

“From who?”

“Audrey’s new star,” he says the last word with a hint of derision. “Though I’d be surprised if she hasn’t already been through half the men in this party.”

Nathalie scowls at that. “Where is she?”

“The one in yellow.”

“You’re taller than me, I can’t see her from all these people,” she says, but she obliges his desire to hide by turning and stepping just in front of him. After another thought, she hands him her glass.

“Pretend we’re discussing something,” she says.

Gabriel only stares at her, and then on the glass she’s given her.

“But what are we discussing, exactly?”

Nathalie shrugs. “I don’t know, the company?”

He scowls. “I’ve had enough of that topic in the last few hours.”

“Good to know I’m not the only one.”

Gabriel winces in commiseration, and snags a wine glass from a passing waiter, handing it to her.

“If I’m talking and drinking then you should be as well,” he says. Nathalie doesn’t point out that he could have just given her the glass back and taken one for himself. But he sips from *her* glass like it’s been his all along, and it hasn’t escaped her notice that he’s standing far closer than they’ve ever been compared to the other fêtes they’ve attended together.

“Thank you,” she murmurs.

"It's the least I can do," he rumbles back, "I should—I should do more for you Nathalie. For all you do for me."

"You look after me pretty well," she says, but her joke falls…not *flat,* no. It comes out sounding like something *different* in the dim room full of clustered people in a way it never would in the bright, professional, *empty* Atelier.

"Do I?"

"I have a very impressive remuneration package."

"You know that's not what I meant. And—aren't we more than that?"

She takes a drink from her glass. It gives her something to swallow with her feelings, a way to stall for time, and the sharp taste is a distraction from the heavy silver gaze of his eyes, that look darker in this light like storm clouds.

"I don't think it's in my contract to protect you from supermodels."

"Oh so you did see her then?"

"Oh, so she *is* pretty then?"

Now Gabriel is the one gulping down his drink, "...she's barely older than *Adrien.* "

Nathalie raises an eyebrow, "She's twenty."

"How—"

"I read the guest list, Gabriel. It took me a moment to put it together but, *Audrey's new star,* that has to be *Style Queen's* current cover model right? The one she's pushing as the alternative to all those celebrity Americans?"

"She is. And before now," he grimaces, "she's a good face for a camera though less impressive in person but I was just trying to appraise her for a campaign when she threw herself at me, Nathalie. Like some sort of bird of prey."

"Maybe she thought she *had* to. Not that you run a casting couch, and she's silly not to have done her research there but…not every man in this industry is you." In fact, given Hawk Moth, "No man in this industry is you."

"I think it was a rather different position she was trying to fill than the star of my new campaign."

Nathalie sends him a look of pity even as she fights down the sudden surge of irritation at the implication.

"I'm sorry. It can't be easy when people assume you're—," but they don't talk about Emilie unless it's about ways to get her back. "—available."

"Why should *you* be sorry? You haven't done anything; as a matter of fact, I know you've done your best to shield me from the worst of the fallout from…well. You know."

She's tried to anyway. But stood here, so close to him she can feel the warmth of his chest while his lips touch the same glass hers had, acting as his shield from conversation; it feels rather like she's taken part of his wife's place anyway.

"I was expressing condolences, not an apology."

Though maybe she should. For inching into Emilie's place everyday. For failing to save her. For *wanting* to be his wife much more than the woman he's currently hiding from could ever feel.

Gabriel doesn't reply. He merely gazes into his drink like it will give him all the answers he's been looking for. Nathalie mentally curses herself for bringing up the topic and brings the glass to her lips. The champagne is sharp on her tongue but she drains half of it in one gulp as the awkward silence extends.

"Sometimes I wonder…" he starts, before trailing off into silence. Nathalie waits for him to finish his thought, but he only takes a sip of his glass. From this close, she can see the way his brows furrowed into his "thinking" expression, the face he makes when he's working on a particularly troublesome design.

Nathalie is content to stand and wait until he's figured out whatever he needed to figure out, but that moment arrives far too soon—Gabriel's silver eyes snap from his glass to stare at her, emotions passing through so fast that for all of her experience in interpreting his moods, they fail her as his face finally settles into one of…shock?

"What is it?" Nathalie asks, concerned. He opens his mouth to reply but nothing comes out. The near-empty glass in his hand trembles lightly where he stands.

"What's wr—"

"Hi!"

The overly-cheerful, unfamiliar voice grates at her ears as she turns around, and Audrey's new star is indeed in front of them both. The blonde hair looks even more fake from this close and it's clear there's been *work* done to plump the lips up. Nathalie can concede that she does look attractive and worthy of gracing the front page of *Style Queen* but given what Gabriel had said about her, she can feel her metaphorical hackles rise up.

"Good evening—"

"M. Agreste, we haven't had a chance to finish our talk earlier!" the blonde greets loudly, drawing more than a few eyes to their position. Nathalie's mouth flattens into the thin line that is her standard when dealing with "difficult" clients. The model tries to step closer to Gabriel but Nathalie's body is blocking the way so she is left to sway uncertainly on her heels.

Gabriel, very notably, doesn't reply. His eyes have gone from their widened state to a narrow-eyed scowl that usually precludes a scathing comment or a blistering retort, and with so many eyes watching them Nathalie isn't as free as she usually is to cut in and escort him away.

A scandal such as the public dismissal of *Style Queen* 's newest model wouldn't impact the brand much, but it would make waves in the fashion industry nonetheless. Nathalie needs him to close his mouth and think *very carefully* about what he will say in reply, but much to her surprise Gabriel stays silent.

The lack of a reply doesn't seem to deter the model much as she launches into a spirited retelling of the events of how she was "discovered" by Audrey Bourgois. To her credit, it only sounds a *little* self-aggrandizing, as opposed to some of the people Nathalie has met at these events, Audrey included.

Then while she was bragging about being on the Graham Norton Show, Gabriel grabs Nathalie's hand.

Nathalie looks at it in surprise. The blonde in front of her falters, green eyes fixed on their conjoined hands.

"I apologise, but me and Nathalie have somewhere to be," Gabriel says as he *turns and walks away* . Nathalie has no choice but to go along with him as her hand is tugged lightly in his wake. Her last sight of the blonde is of her dumbfounded, slightly offended face as Gabriel guides her to the exit of the party, curious eyes following them.

Mentally, she winces. While the party *is* exclusive, the damage control she will have to do for tonight is already enough to give her a headache.

Nathalie feels dizzy as Gabriel pulls her out of the room, away from the press of the people, and the music. It's almost cold in the corridor in comparison, and she shivers. The silence of the empty hallway surrounds them as Gabriel comes to a stop just before the elevator doors.

He turns to face her but he doesn't let go of her hand. He's breathing heavily, like he'd just come from running, and his eyes are dark with something that Nathalie only ever seen directed at *someone else* before. But he's only looking at her now.

Her mouth is dry as she runs through the events of the night: Gabriel hiding from the model, talking about his perceived "availability", the blatant advance of said model when they are finally found. Then his sudden escape from the party with her in tow.

A moment later she has the wall hard against her back, and Gabriel is warm and firm covering her front. "Sir," she says, and it's supposed to be a reprimand but it comes out like a groan as his mouth finds her neck and his thumb finds the top of the high splits in the skirt of her otherwise demure dress.

His teeth worry a bruise in her neck that nothing but her turtlenecks could hide, and despite this information all she could feel is the way he's mouthing at her, pressing his body against her, grinding his pelvis against her until she could feel his desire even through four layers of clothing.

The door to the party is *right there* and she's getting necked in the hallway just outside it. What little of Nathalie's brain that hasn't been taken over by surprise, lust, and sheer joy is actively blaring alarm bells; someone could come outside and see them like this—!

Gabriel's hand disengages from their journey up her dress to slam on the elevator buttons. The lift must have already been on that floor because it opens almost immediately; Gabriel breaks off from his enthusiastic exploration of her collarbone to look at her with swollen lips and dark, intense eyes.

"Come on," he says, and as always, she follows him.

Nathalie's never been so thankful that she had the foresight to book a room in this hotel. Her right sleeve is already half down her arm and his lips have been busy marking her neck purple; she considers herself very lucky that there doesn't seem to be any staff roaming the upper floors of the hotel.

God, the tabloids *would* have a field day if they saw them like this.

When they reach the door to their room, Nathalie has to break away from his enthusiastic exploration of her collarbone to dig her card out of her purse. His eyes are darkened with lust and his cravat is untucked from his suit that she doesn't remember doing. He doesn't let go of her waist as Nathalie fumbles with the card and swipes it on the scanner.

As she swings the door open it occurs to her that he hasn't spoken since he all but dragged her to the elevator. The lights flare on in the room and momentarily blind her; Gabriel takes the card from her fingers and slots it into the switch.

When the door closes, he presses it down until there's an audible click, and the lights turn off again. The heavy curtains obscure the light coming from outside and the curtain muffles the sound from the party downstairs so all Nathalie could hear in the darkness is their heavy breaths. Even her heartbeat sounds far too loud in her ears.

As the seconds drag on without any more movement from him, Nathalie feels herself falter. She could feel the bruise his teeth had left on her neck and perhaps it's enough—perhaps he thinks it was a mistake—it *was* a mistake and she can't fool herself by thinking otherwise—and so when she turns to where she thinks the switch is, aiming to turn the lights on again, the hand on her cheek startles her.

"Gabriel—!"

Nathalie squeaks, but his thumb pressing softly on her lips silences anything she might have said. As her eyes slowly adjust to the darkness, the shine of his silver eyes are the first thing that she sees.

"Shh," is all he says before he kisses her again.

It's different from back there, in the hallway—his kiss is soft and tender, lips coaxing hers open and his tongue exploring her mouth with a gentleness he didn't have before. He tilts his head and it's so much better; so much *more* . Her hands gravitate to his back as his fingers pull hairpins away from her carefully constructed bun until her hair falls in a cascade but he keeps them anchored on her head to keep her close as he kisses her with all the tenderness of a lover.

She refuses to dwell more on that last thought. Not that there's many thoughts running through her head with how she can feel his desire even through their clothes. They break apart for air only to dive back in again, but this time their glasses clatter against each other and the sound feels awfully loud in the silence of the room.

Gabriel pulls away from her. Nathalie feels the loss keenly even as guilt sets in, but he only tucks her hair back into her ear before he leans in to press a brief kiss to her forehead.

"I want to hear you say ' *yes'* ," he says quietly.

She swallows. "If I don't?"

"Then I wish you a *good night* then, Nathalie."

He sounds so monotone with this statement that she could practically feel the way he's forcing himself to be polite, even as the waver in his voice when he says her name betrays his true feelings on the matter.

"...and if I do?" she says, because she needs to *hear* him say it.

"Then…" his thumb finds the edge of her other sleeve, slipping under the fabric as he rubs circles in her skin.

"I want to hear you say it over—"

The rest of his fingers curl along the edge and slide the sleeve down her arm, exposing the skin to the cool air of the room, but Nathalie feels warm from the weight of his gaze.

"—and over—"

As her chest is exposed his hands busy themselves with pulling her sleeves all the way down her arms until she's naked from the waist up; the bra offers little protection against the way his fingertips dance on the lace of her bra as he steps forward just a little bit closer.

"—and over again," he says against the shell of her ear.

Once again he pulls away, his hands falling by his sides as he braces himself where he stands. It's the exact same stance he takes when he's embarrassed and trying not to show it, but in the darkness it looks more like he's bracing himself for a blow.

"Is that alright?" he asks, and the rawness of his voice undoes her.

"Yes," she whispers back, and Gabriel surges forward to claim her lips once again.

From there it's a blur of rustling fabric and harsh, wanton sounds—Gabriel's lips rarely leave hers in the time it took for him to strip her down to nakedness, and his expensive suit is similarly abandoned on the floor as he lays her down on the bed. The sheets are cool against her overheated body as she writhes under his attention, constant and unrelenting, hands gripping bare flesh tight enough to leave marks.

“Yes,” she says when his fingers tease at the edges of her breasts. He takes one in his large hand as his mouth descends on the other and Nathalie moans at the filthy way he begins to lap and suck at her nipples while his hand squeezes the other until she’s clawing at his back, trying to push him down to where she needed him the most.

When Gabriel finally removes his mouth, his hands migrate to her hips, fingertips sinking slightly into the soft flesh as he presses soft kisses from the valley of her chest down to her stomach, and finally down to her belly. Nathalie expects him to continue down to where she’s embarrassingly wet for him, but instead Gabriel…pauses.

The weight of his gaze is heavy on her skin. Her glasses have long since been abandoned along with the rest of her clothes but she could still see the faint glint of his silver eyes as they focus on her stomach.

“What’s wro—”

Gabriel breaks out of his stupor to kiss her once again, and this time she could feel the desperation and pure need behind the kiss. Nathalie responds in kind, and as his hand travels over her stomach he only pulls back to press a tender kiss to her forehead before he looks expectantly, almost *chidingly* at her.

This time, Nathalie knows what to do.

“Yes,” she says with swollen lips, and Gabriel immediately withdraws to hitch her legs up to his hips. His cock presses teasingly against her cunt but he doesn’t enter her, not yet—he reaches over to pull a pillow from where it’s been shoved away from their activities, and lifts her slightly to place it under her back.

Despite herself, Nathalie’s traitorous heart swells. The pillow makes it easier on her back with how tall Gabriel is, and she appreciates deeply how he can still care about her comfort even in the heat of the moment. He adjusts her legs to better slot himself in between them and she’s momentarily struck by thought of riding him with nothing but her black stiletto heels on —

And then he’s sinking into her, his cock parting her folds, and Nathalie's legs jerk as she revels in the sensation of being *filled* . He’s big and long and when he bottoms out Nathalie could see the obscene way her stomach swells just a little bit outward with his girth and she can’t help but throw her head back with a loud moan.

“Yes,” she manages to choke out as his pelvis rubs into her clit, and it didn’t take them long to find a hard, punishing rhythm; Gabriel all but lifts her up from the bed with the force of his thrusts and Nathalie can do nothing but cry out and brace herself against the headboard as he fucks her hard and fast.

Her body tightens around his cock and he howls incoherently, a sentiment Nathalie echoes with a broken moan as he drives her closer and closer to the edge with every eager stroke. It’s all a little too fast and a little too rough and they’re both out of control but she just wants him *more* ; wants whatever he’s willing to give her, wants the world to stop turning so she can enjoy the feeling of him holding her close and bringing her to the heights of pleasure before

they both come back down to real world. Nathalie's lips meet his in a quick and messy kiss when he bends down and oh, that feels both too much and too little, the yearning in her chest growing stronger even as lust takes over her.

He pauses just to push her legs up even higher and the new angle makes her body stretch and his cock to hit at the *just the right spot —*

"Yes!" Nathalie screams as the world dissolves into nothing but sparks in her eyes. Waves of pleasure wash over her as he fucks her through her own orgasm and into his; warm liquid spilling into her as he buries his cock inside her cunt and comes with an equally loud moan.

An eternity later, Nathalie feels him slip out of her and settle on her side. Instinct has her curling up against his chest, exhausted and yet so, so *satisfied* .

She doesn't have the strength to move away when his hands pull her close in a tight embrace, large hands rubbing up and down her back as she catches her breath. His own breaths tickle as he kisses her forehead softly, once, twice, and then he tucks her under his chin.

She should move away. She should get out of this bed and leave. This is a mistake, and both of them knew it. He's married and she's only his assistant and yet…she makes no move to escape his embrace. It's all too intimate for words and the silence feels too comfortable for her to break. She just can't bring herself to do it, not now.

Maybe in the morning.

Maybe.

Maybe…

Nathalie falls asleep to the sound of his soft snores against her hair.

It's still dark when he wakes her up with his head between her legs. She comes awake to the flutter of his tongue against her clit and his hands holding her hips down until she can do nothing but mindlessly grind back until she climaxes with a hoarse moan.

He doesn't wait for her to recover as he coaxes her on her arms, hands travelling down her bare back to squeeze her arse and lift her up on her knees. Gabriel growls as he thrusts home, the different angle and the recent orgasm making Nathalie's head spin even as she is once again dragged to the edge. He grabs her hips close every time he pushes in, kneading her arse cheeks before pulling out swiftly until only the tip is left, the emptiness always making her whimper until he plunges back in.

It's driving her to the brink; *he's* driving her to the brink and Nathalie is swept away in the current of his passion, arms unsteady from the force of his thrusts. He bends down to curve his body around her—one hand on her chest and another on her belly while he licks the bruises he's made on her neck—and when she comes again, Gabriel is there to lay her down gently on her front as colours burst into life behind her eyes.

He fills her with his own climax only moments later, still gently rubbing circles in her belly as he catches his breath against her back.

Two orgasms in a row in the middle of the night seemed to block any coherent thought from forming in her brain, and Nathalie simply lets her simple and satisfied body be moved until his chest is warm against her back and their feet are curled up against each other. When she drifts off again, it’s with a blissful smile on her face.

When her alarm rings, Nathalie's arm works on autopilot, reaching over to the nightstand to turn it off. Her fingers meet bare, empty wood instead of a cool glass surface, and she fumbles around blindly for either her glasses or said phone to meet her fingers only to wind up slapping the laminated wood repeatedly.

The noise of her alarm sounds like it's coming from farther away. She sighs, annoyed; she'd probably left it in her coat again. Though the lack of her glasses was a surprise—perhaps they had fallen down from the nightstand?

It wasn't until she tried to reach further back when she realised that she's stuck.

She's being *held* .

Nathalie's eyes fly open as she jumps from being barely awake to fully awake from shock.

She's being held by *Gabriel Agreste* .

Nathalie closes her eyes back down in a pitiful attempt at denial. Her alarm is still persistently ringing from where her purse had been thrown away in the heat of last night’s events so she can’t even try to go back to sleep. What *had* happened felt far too much like one of her dreams, and yet the soreness in between her legs betrays the reality of the situation.

She’d slept with her boss. Had sex with Gabriel Agreste, *loudly* and *enthusiastically* if the scratch in her throat is any indication.

Her alarm is still ringing, and it’s suddenly very important to remember why it’s ringing instead of facing, well, *him* . She normally doesn’t have alarms this late in the morning, especially with the sunlight managing to penetrate the thick blackout curtains on the windows. It only serves to remind her more of her current situation, curled up in Gabriel’s arms after a night of admittedly *very good* sex.

She can already foresee the awkwardness later when they’re on the plane.

Oh right.

That ’s why she has the alarm.

"We need to get up," Nathalie says out loud. The arms around her refuse to budge.

"Gabriel. We have a flight in two hours."

"D'nwnto."

His head buries itself further into her hair as his legs trap hers in place. The stickiness of their combined come makes her wince but his body's warmth on her bare skin is a dream unearned. Nevertheless, they need to get ready unless they want to be left by the plane.

"Gabriel, please."

"...no."

She sighs.

"Come on, you can shower with me." Nathalie says, mostly to see what he'd do given the way he won't relinquish his hold on her. "We need to get clean."

"Or," He kisses her crown, "we could stay here a little longer, and clean up later."

"We have a flight to catch."

"Reschedule it."

" *Gabriel,* " she groans, "do you know how annoyed literally everyone involved will be if they do that. And then they'll be annoyed at *me.* "

He groans this time. "I'll tell them it was my fault."

She shuts her eyes. She's not sure she can say he *owes* her; he's been very generous, but she needs that generosity to be somewhere *more* than just in bed.

Ha. Just in bed. As if she'd ever thought this would happen outside her dreams.

But it has. So she's not embarrassed like an assistant shirking her duties when she asks, " *Please* ."

He sucks in a breath. "I don't want to leave this moment. Can't we just stay in this bed forever, you and I, and forget the rest of the world?"

Her heart aches for him. And for her. Because what happens when they *do* have to face the rest of the world?

She calculates the time in her head, they need to be out of this room in an hour really if they're not going to be late for their scheduled take off time, even allowing for the car taking them to the plane and skipping the terminal.

And she can't call the butler service to pack their bags with her and Gabriel like *this,* not unless she wants this gossip about before she even knows about what this is. Besides it's not like there's much to pack, they'd only been here for the weekend.

Thank god she's got her turtleneck to hide the bruises that must be there, sparing her some make-up time, but there's a tenderness to her jaw line that suggests Gabriel got there too and

she’s going to have to go at it with foundation and concealer.

“We can have half an hour longer,” she offers, “but then we really *do* have to leave. Unless you reschedule the plane. And make my life much harder than it has to be.”

He pulls her upright as he sits up. “Only for you my dear Nathalie, I don't—it's never been my aim to make your life difficult."

"I know," she shivers as he kisses a tender spot on her neck, still not relinquishing his hold on her, and if he asked her to let them stay here now she doesn't know that she has the strength to say no again.

So instead she turns her head to meet his lips; this still feels like a dream but if it's real she wants to kiss him in the daylight at least once.

And he obliges her. It's not as gentle as the first one they'd had in this room, nor as desperate as the ones after.

It's slow but deep like he's trying to memorise her mouth and—

It feels like he's saying goodbye.

When they break apart for air, Nathalie is desperate to grab onto something, anything to distract herself from the prickle of tears in her eyes.

“I’m showering,” she says brusquely, swinging her legs to the side. “You can either join me, or—”

It's almost funny how fast he leaps out of bed, dragging her with him. And that is how Nathalie finds herself an uncountable amount of time later, clutching the glass wall of the shower desperately as he eats her out below like she’s a feast and he’s a starving man. He keeps her legs braced open and ready as he sucks her clit and draws letters using that skilled tongue.

“Ye-es!” she cries out as her body shudders with a climax, and he thrusts two fingers in her cunt to help her ride through it. When she finally catches her breath, Gabriel stands up and with a smirk, puts those two fingers in his mouth to suck them clean.

Nathalie lurches forward to crash her lips into his, moaning brokenly as she can taste her own come from his mouth. Gabriel returns the kiss just as eagerly, kneading the soft curve of her arse as he nestles his cock between her legs.

“Can you take more?” he asks after they part for air, and oh, the smugness in his voice makes her want to *punish* him.

“Shouldn’t I be asking you that?” Nathalie retorts, snaking one hand down to pump his cock. His eyes roll back into his head as he thrusts into her fist, and she would love *nothing more* than to repay the favour and suck his cock until he comes down her throat, but they’re on a time limit.

So she turns and braces herself against the shower wall, his arse brushing against his cock, and is rewarded by an erotic gasp and the welcome pressure of his cock against her pussy.

Nathalie would have thought he'd go hard and fast like he'd done last night, but he curves his body over hers as his cock sinks slowly into her until he's bottomed out. Then he coaxes her into a half-bent, half-standing position, her breasts pressing crudely against the cold glass wall as he presses kisses to her back.

In this position, the pressure on Nathalie's arms is eased up completely as her weight rests entirely in Gabriel's hold. She's left to relish the feeling of his arms around hers in the light of the bathroom, his cock pulling ever so slowly out and pushing back in just a little faster, just enough for her to feel every vein and every drag against the walls of her pussy. Nathalie whimpers, and his kisses land on her back like the flutter of a butterfly's wings.

It's…intimate. It's soft and it's sweet and it's nothing at all like the fast, almost mindless pace of last night. It doesn't feel like *fucking* is the right word for what they're doing now; a crude and ungainly term for the way she melts into his embrace and him leaning against her while he thrusts slow and unhurried.

It feels…well. It feels like they're *making love* .

And at that thought, her eyes prickle once again with tears. Damn her heart for thinking more of this when she has no *right* ; when she's nothing to him but his assistant and perhaps a friend but never something *more* .

When she climaxes, Nathalie lets herself slump in his arms to hide the trail of tears on her cheeks, letting the spray of the shower wash the tracks away.

"Are you alright?" he huffs as he pulls out of her but he doesn't release her from his embrace.

"I'm fine," she replies, hoping he'll chalk up the thickness of her voice to her recent orgasm. Under the steady spray of the shower, they stay entwined, unwilling to be the first to move away. The glass shower wall is fogged up and she isn't wearing her glasses but she imagines the sight they must make anyway; the picture of intimacy, for all that it's not *real* .

Gabriel gives her neck one final kiss before stepping back.

"Let me," he says, reaching for her shampoo.

They would have been much faster with washing up if Gabriel hadn't kept kissing her at every step, and even slower if she wasn't there to remind him of the time. But they get out of the shower just fine (even if Gabriel steals one more kiss from her lips before she steps out of the bathroom).

Then she takes a look at the time.

" *Merde* ," Nathalie swears out loud.

"What—"

“We only have *half an hour* —!”

They must have looked a *sight* as they arrived at the hangar. Nathalie’s usual bun isn’t as prim and as neat as it usually is, having had to tie it into a quick, messy bun in the car. Gabriel’s cravat is missing, but he wears it well with a slightly unbuttoned shirt beneath the suit jacket, even if his hair isn’t as tightly gelled as it normally is.

“Good morning M. Agreste, Mme. Sancoeur!” The lone flight attendant greets them with a cheerful, professional smile, and very conspicuously says nothing about how they arrived with only five minutes to spare. Nathalie attempts to greet her back but the name escapes her; all she remembers is that it starts with the letter ‘M’.

She settles for a cordial nod, and is gratified when she accepts this as enough pleasantries and starts the preparations for take-off. The next few minutes are spent in awkward silence as they both settle in the plane, avoiding each other’s eyes.

"I almost thought you'd have the beds laid out," Nathalie finally says as the plane starts to taxi.

"They can't do that before take off."

"Ah. *Are* we doing that then?"

A sheepish expression crosses Gabriel's face. "That might depend on you."

She raises an eyebrow at him. "Is this...something we're going to get another chance to do?"

Gabriel swallows. He’s not looking at her when he answers.

"I'm married."

"You were married last night,” she retorts. “And when we almost missed this flight."

"I know, but I—," he swallows and cuts himself off. Nathalie very carefully doesn’t look at him as the plane lifts from the ground.

"If this is your way of saying it can't happen again,” she starts, keeping her voice steady, “then we don't have to talk about it. We wanted each other, we gave in, and now we're going to be professional again. When the wheels hit the runway in Paris, this *never happened* . But don't try to blame this on being *drunk* , Gabriel. Not after this morning. Not after you made *me* confirm I wanted every bit of it."

He’d stiffened up when she’d cut him off, but the more she talked the more he seemed to slump in his seat. When he looks at her, his eyes are dark with the same kind of unreadable *something* that Nathalie had seen right before he kissed her for the first time.

"Alcohol is a great lowerer of inhibitions,” he admits, “but it's never made a man do anything he doesn't want to do already. You are...entrancing, my dear Nathalie.”

“I—”

“ *Addictive* .” Gabriel breathes, and as the light of the morning sun hits his jawline she all but blushes at the faint red lines where her nails have dug in last night.

His next words, however, pour a bucket of cold water on her ardour.

“But I can't pretend I'm free to indulge anymore."

Nathalie leans back against the seat with an inward sigh. "Then we forget this. When we land in Paris."

"Yes." Then his eyes widen. "When we *land* in Paris?"

"You wanted to take every taste you could while you were indulging, didn't you? Did you assume I was any different?”

He swallows. "I would have thought you were…ah, *too sore* to do anything."

"I am," she confirms. The overhead lights switch to green as the pilot gives the all clear, and Nathalie unbuckles her safety belt and moves to sit on Gabriel’s lap. Her fingers toy with his lapels as she curls up into him, tucking her head below his chin.

"I just want to do this,” she says, and closes her eyes with a pleased hum.

Gabriel looks down at where she's curled up on top of him, her warm weight a. gentle callback to the way she felt like home in his arms last night. His own arms rise up to her waist, holding her secure against him. Nathalie smiles against his neck and for a moment, Gabriel is free to pretend.

End Notes

idea and dialogue by fleurjaune; cameo by a famous comic artist

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